

Centering Black Voices: Lessons Learned and Reflections from a Large-Scale AAVE Data Collection at a Historically Black University

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Abstract

Collecting African American Vernacular English (AAVE) voice data presents challenges in balancing trust, community interests, and technological advancements. This study uses an autoethnographic approach to examine a collaboration between researchers at Howard University, a Historically Black College/University (HBCU), and an industry partner. We explore the challenges and opportunities that arise when HBCU researchers conduct large-scale data collection within their communities. Our findings highlight the key role HBCUs play in ethically collecting data from communities of color, emphasizing community-centered methods and the complexities of managing partnerships. We provide recommendations for future collaborations that prioritize community needs and advance technological equity, focusing on four key factors including managing trust and data ethics, managing community engagement, resource management, and managing power dynamics. This work contributes to ongoing discussions on ethical AI development, cultural preservation, and the role of HBCUs in shaping the future of voice recognition technology.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**.

Keywords

AI Ethics, Voice Data Collection, Autoethnography

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1 Introduction

As artificial intelligence (AI) and voice recognition technologies rapidly advance, they risk perpetuating and amplifying existing societal biases, particularly in communities of color. This concerning trend highlights the critical need for more inclusive and representative data in Large Language Models (LLMs) that power various AI-driven systems. Recognizing this challenge, our team at Howard University, a Historically Black University (HBCU) collaborated with a big tech industry partner to address the underrepresentation of Black voices in AI datasets, particularly in Automatic Speech Recognition (ASR) systems. Automatic and algorithmic bias in technology often results in the exclusion and misrepresentation of Black culture [8]. These biases are also evident in various areas like facial recognition, predictive policing, and employment algorithms, which disproportionately affect Black individuals and communities [4, 5, 15]. These issues arise from factors such as developer bias, data bias, and annotator bias, which perpetuate inaccuracies and inequalities in technology.

African American Vernacular English (AAVE) is a distinct linguistic system with its own grammar, vocabulary, and pronunciation, representing the cultural and historical experiences of Black communities [9]. However, it has often been dismissed as “improper” or “informal,” reflecting societal biases that devalue Black speech [19, 20]. This linguistic oppression extends to technology, where ASR systems frequently misinterpret AAVE, further marginalizing its speakers [1, 6]. The historical relationship between America and African Americans in data collection has been fraught

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with exploitation, erasure, and misrepresentation. From the transatlantic slave trade to modern-day algorithmic biases, data practices have often reinforced racial hierarchies and systemic inequalities [2, 10, 16, 21, 23]. Today, there is a growing effort to empower Black communities through equitable data practices, as highlighted in work by Roberts' "Fatal Invention" [18], which emphasizes the importance of examining biases embedded in technology, and Benjamin's "Race After Technology" [1], which critiques how digital tools continue to exploit Black communities.

HBCUs, with their deep-rooted connections to the Black community and longstanding commitment to advancing equity, are uniquely positioned to lead efforts in ethical and respectful data collection. This collaboration between our team at Howard University and an industry partner presented an opportunity to shape the future of AI in a manner that honors and respects Black voices and experiences. The data collection effort resulted in 600 hours of audio data from AAVE speakers from various regions across the United States including the Northeastern, Midwest, Southern, West etc. This distribution allowed us to capture the rich regional variations of dialects, ensuring a comprehensive and accurate representation in language models [22]. We employed a community-centered approach to collecting the data, leveraging personal networks and local community businesses across the United States to host both in-person and virtual recruitment sessions. These sessions were designed not only to collect data but also to educate, inform, and celebrate the community.

This case study examines the following research questions:

- RQ1: How can HBCUs engage in large-scale data collection within the Black community while safeguarding, honoring, and respecting community interests?
- RQ2: What key lessons can be derived from an HBCU research team's experience in large-scale data collection within the Black community and collaboration with an industry partner?
- RQ3: What insights have HBCU teams gained regarding communication, resource allocation, and equity in partnership dynamics?

Data sovereignty and ownership are vital considerations within the Black Data Ecosystem. This work emphasizes the need for cultural autonomy over data practices to prevent exploitation and misrepresentation [7, 11, 13]. By directly involving communities in data collection, annotation, and model training, researchers can create AI systems that more accurately represent and respect linguistic diversity, leading to more equitable outcomes. We present lessons learned and recommendations for how academia, industry, and community partnerships can collaborate effectively, demonstrating the value of inclusive data practices and creating a more equitable technological landscape.

2 Methods

Our core research team consisted of one tenured professor, four research scientists, and one undergraduate researcher within the Human-Centered AI Institute at Howard University. Four of the five members of the core team identify as Black-American, while one identifies as South Asian (Nepali). Throughout the study, we collaborated closely with three AAVE literary experts, a transcription

company, and an industry partner. Collectively, our core team and partners brought fifteen years of experience in AAVE language and dialect studies, along with diverse expertise in community-based data collection and research methods. We use an autoethnographic approach to reflect on our experiences as researchers at Howard University conducting large-scale audio data collection efforts with Black communities across the United States. In this case study, we reflect on the experiences of the core research team and how we situate ourselves in this work as members of the larger Black community in the United States and as researchers at Howard University.

2.1 Data Collection and Analysis

Data collection took place between August 2023 and June 2024. We traveled to various regions within the United States (Northeast, South, and West) to facilitate community-centered events to engage with the Black community members. During this time, researchers independently reflected on the successes and challenges throughout the large-scale data collection efforts. At the end of the data collection, we conducted a virtual affinity diagramming exercise to organize key lessons learned using Miro [14]. Each researcher detailed their insights and experiences. We then grouped insights by using thematic analysis to identify the key themes. All quotes are drawn from our independent reflections.

3 Results

This case study examines the complex power dynamics at the intersection of human-computer interaction, advances in AI, and the Black Data Ecosystem. We define the Black Data Ecosystem as a network prioritizing Black experiences, data sovereignty, and ethical empowerment. Defining this ecosystem is essential for articulating a framework that centers historically marginalized perspectives, particularly as they relate to data-driven technologies that have disproportionately excluded or harmed Black communities. As researchers with diverse identities within this ecosystem, we navigated the challenging task of balancing the interests of multiple stakeholders, including African American community participants, an industry partner, institutional objectives, and broader research goals. Our analysis highlights the intricate negotiations required to equitably distribute power, center historically marginalized voices, and maintain ethical and scholarly integrity. Through an autoethnographic reflection on researcher-community, researcher-industry, researcher-institution, and researcher-research goal relationships, we explore how intentionality and accountability can mitigate power imbalances and foster inclusive outcomes. This introspective approach highlights the complexities of maintaining ethical integrity, fostering community engagement, and negotiating authority within the Black Data Ecosystem.

3.1 Researcher Collaboration with the Black Community

"As a Black woman researcher at an HBCU in computer science, I often sat and thought about how my Black community is included in research or large-scale communities. I often volunteer and engage in seminars, talks, and events at Howard with other Black

people around the community surrounding Howard or in the Northeast where I currently live. I knew that I needed this large-scale data collection of AAVE to be special and involve all of the community while letting them know this is for you and you're helping us protect what we built for later. Throughout my time planning the community recruitment conversations, I couldn't wait to have discussions with Black people and talk about why it's important to speak freely and discuss the ways AAVE changes according to the area you live in and around the Washington, DC area, Atlanta area, or other places throughout the South and Northeast. I was so happy to have conversations about code-switching ... I am from Missouri and when I get comfortable I speak with my Midwestern twang mixed with the vernacular of the DC area. I often use Alexa, Siri, or other voice assistants while driving or while working around my house, but unfortunately rarely are they able to understand me and the unique way I say things. I knew this had to be shared with others at the panel discussions and wanted to tell a funny story to start off the community conversations of my own experience. We also talked about the importance of seeing yourself in tech and how technologies like Siri and Alexa not understanding Black people reinforces Black people not belonging in tech. ... We reiterated that this community is "all love" and our data collection effort will continue on to create something that Black people would be proud of. So many people gave me hugs and said 'What took tech so long to care?' – Author5

HBCUs bear a unique responsibility to their communities, ensuring fair research practices and community involvement in large-scale data collection efforts. This was exemplified in the creation of the Howard University African American Vernacular English (AAVE) dataset, where we positioned HBCUs, Black churches, conferences, and other "safe spaces" to play a crucial role during the development. These non-judgmental environments allowed people to speak freely, often joyfully expressing relief at not having to code-switch. The community's support was expressed, with participants hugging researchers and enthusiastically backing AI informed by their Black experience. Inspired by the historical call "Tell them we are rising!" [17], we organized community-centered events that began with discussions on AAVE's importance and often concluded with participants spreading the word, creating a network of supporters. This grassroots approach led to the formation of an HBCU consortium for data protection and study. While our community-centered approach established a strong foundation for our research, our work also required navigating relationships with various organizational partners, each bringing its own set of dynamics to the project.

3.1.1 Collaborating with Community Organizations and Smaller Startups. In our experience, collaborating with both smaller startups and community organizations presented a complex set of advantages and challenges. Working with smaller companies, such as the audio and video data collection platform called Phonic, offered greater flexibility and responsiveness compared to larger,

more established tools. We were able to directly communicate with Phonic's engineers to quickly adapt the platform to our research needs, despite the lack of comprehensive documentation. This level of personalized support was invaluable, as it allowed us to address issues and refine the tool to better suit our project requirements.

Similarly, our collaboration with a small transcription company proved beneficial in preserving the integrity of the African American Vernacular English (AAVE) data. Larger transcription services or AI-based tools often inadvertently "correct" AAVE to Standard American English (SAE), which would have undermined the core purpose of our data collection efforts. The smaller transcription company's flexibility and direct communication enabled us to ensure the transcripts accurately reflected the nuances of AAVE.

However, working with smaller entities also presented its own set of challenges. We found that community organizations were sometimes hesitant or overwhelmed by the prospect of collaborating on a large-scale research project. This resulted in instances where we were "ghosted" by potential partners, as they struggled to accommodate our requests within their resources and capacity.

3.1.2 Trust.

"As I look through tons of emails from participants asking about where their payment are and some expressing dissatisfaction about not yet receiving their study compensation, my heart sinks to my stomach. The only thing I can do is reassure them that we have the money to pay them and to sit tight, but I know that is not a good enough answer. On another tab, my email is open, which shows the many emails I have sent to various administration officials to inquire about the transfer of money and when compensation will be processed for participants. Then I have to take this news to the industry partner and hope that they are also reassured about the payment issues we are having. This whole situation has given me serious anxiety where I can feel it physically and mentally. I always put myself into the shoes of the participants because I am also a member of their community." – Author 2

Trust became a main barrier to engagement with our data collection efforts based on participants' skepticism about what their data would be used for and the questioning of Howard University's credibility when expectations were not met. When recruiting participants at community events, they had questions about their data privacy, such as "Who will have direct access to my audio?" and "What can and cannot be done with my data?" In our response to them, we explained that,

"while our data collection partnership is an industry/academic collaboration, the data is OWNED by Howard University. It was important to express that our team is highly protective of this data and that our policies regarding how the data will be responsibly handled and cared for by our institution." – Author3

We also highlighted that the industry partner would use audio data to improve African American speech recognition, but Howard University maintains overall data control and privacy responsibility.

FAIR AI usage guidelines¹ were developed by Howard University in the start of the study to protect Black participants from potential AI-related harms. These guidelines were shared at community events and made available online for participant reference.

“As we collaboratively developed the Fair AI Usage guidelines for the AAVE dataset with our industry partner, I needed to know I wasn’t throwing my people under the bus. The resulting guidelines were talked through from every perspective on what might occur in the future with this data.” - Author5

When sharing the research study in conversations with individuals, sometimes we received responses about this study feeding into the “AI problem”. Some individuals were skeptical of the study, fearing AI misuse. One individual said, “Y’all trying to clone us. They are cloning people with AI, and you’re working with them.” while another asked, “Oh, so y’all the opps?” Trust increased when previous participants vouched for the study’s legitimacy. During a virtual session, when someone asked, “Is this real? This seems too good to be true?”, confirmation from a participant’s cousin eased concerns and led to increased participation. Similar vouching occurred in a university group chat. However, negative perceptions of HBCUs persisted. When a payment was delayed, one participant suggested it wouldn’t have happened at a predominantly white institutions (PWI), reflecting broader biases against HBCUs.

As researchers, we consistently held discussions regarding the current sentiments of AI within the Black community. Through those discussions, we aimed to find a balance between addressing concerns and highlighting the positive impact of this study. Our work in AI research does not diminish the reality that AI has the potential to perpetuate systemic bias and inflict harm on us and our community. We felt obligated to protect our community because of our shared lived experiences with the participants, understanding their reluctance to share personal data to institutions who may make unfulfilled promises. Throughout U.S. history there is evidence of it from the Tuskegee experiment [3] to urban renewal and displacement [12]. We strongly advocated for participants when challenges that can affect their experience in the study came about, such as faster payment processing with administration officials and troubleshooting technical issues with the audio survey. During community events, we made sure to participants felt comfortable to ask any question about their participation in the study, future use of their data, and AI in general. But as researchers, we do believe that the Black community has to be involved in the advancement of innovation because too often they are overlooked, left behind, and their information gets told incorrectly. We recognize that there is a higher level of trust with us belonging to the community, however, there is still a power dynamic since we all have doctoral degrees, work at a well-known institution, and have collaborated with a large industry partner that makes AI technology. Having to balance the responsibility of being careful to not cause any harm to participants as research often does unintentionally, while fulfilling the commitment to the data collection process was complicated and at times discomfoting when issues arose.

3.1.3 Power Dynamics. As Black researchers and members of the communities we study, we occupy a unique position that carries both influence and responsibility when navigating the power dynamics inherent in this research. On one hand, our community membership grants us insights and trust, allowing for a more authentic engagement with participants and a deeper understanding of the nuances within the Black data ecosystem. Conversely, our roles as researchers and gatekeepers of knowledge introduce a different kind of power - one that comes with the ability to shape narratives, frame data, and direct research outcomes that will impact the community at large. This dual positionality requires a critical reflection on the ethical implications of wielding such influence.

“The discourse around our project ranged from the highly technical implementation of our data to improve conversational technologies to discussions about the varied nuances of Black speech throughout our nation. Holding space for these nuances to be accepted by speech technologies engage our communities using AAVE that was authentic to our own identities and cultures. Simple greetings like “Hey y’all,” “What it do?,” “Whaddup dummy!”, “Habari gani?” elicited responses from community members that poured into the collective gumbo of AAVE dialects that were present in the space. It was important for me as a researcher to lead principally with the part of myself that is also a member of The Community.”
— Author3

3.2 Researcher Prioritizing Institutional Mission

Navigating the power dynamic between a researcher and the institution involves balancing academic and research goals with the priorities and constraints of the organization. As a researcher, we may push for innovation or culturally sensitive methodologies, while the institution, and industry partner, may prioritize deadlines, funding, and administrative requirements. This can limit a researcher’s autonomy in choosing methods, timelines, and access to resources, even when funding may be available. Researchers must advocate for their work while ensuring they align with institutional missions and maintain the reputation of both their work and the institution.

“In my observation, although we had a solid core team there was a consistent need to interact with smaller teams across campus to accomplish tasks, such as accounts payable for creating checks to send to participants at the beginning of the study, requesting approval on research related tools that would ease the process of the research. We had to continuously brainstorm alternatives to push the needle forward on our data collection efforts because not only did it begin to cause mistrust in completed participants, it also slowed our progress on accomplishing milestones for the industry partners.” - Author 1

The surge in resource demands from the data collection put a strain on the standard institutional processes, leading to substantial slow-downs and setbacks. The high volume of requests for resources and

¹<https://www.elevateblackvoiceshu.com/usage-guidelines>

approvals outpaced the existing capacity of the campus infrastructure. Through working collaboratively together with the Howard leadership by meeting one-on-one to address their concerns, we were able to pilot usage of the external Tango payment system to pay participants versus sending physical checks to over 100 participants weekly. This alleviated the burden on the accounts payable team to process check requests on top of their regular workload.

“As I met weekly with the University leadership to walk-through how we would ensure oversight and compliance with the University policies and IRS guidelines, I was excited when he finally agreed to pilot usage of Tango for paying our participants! This win for the project and the university took much submitting of reports, changing our IRB consent forms, and a general assurance from the team to not mess this up.” - Author5

At the beginning of the study the accounts payable department did not have dedicated personnel to handle these specialized research-related transactions. As a result, the accounting office created a dedicated team just for this project. However, these individuals also had their regular duties which became entangled with the standard accounts payable operations, leading to delays and communication issues. The research team’s heightened utilization of institutional resources put a strain on the standard processes, which were not accustomed to accommodating such high-volume demands from a single project. However, as a result of this project, process improvements created a precedent that is now available to other researchers throughout the institution.

3.3 Researcher Managing Research Outcomes

3.3.1 Data Management & Accessibility. In large-scale voice data collection projects, data management plays a critical role not only in ensuring the success of the project but also in shaping perceptions among participants and stakeholders. The evolving nature of these projects often leads to adjustments in timelines, metadata, and other information to meet both research needs and stakeholder expectations. Balancing the need for robust data management with the requirement for accessibility across multiple stakeholders—such as transcribers, research teams, and external sponsors—was a key challenge in this project. Platforms like Enterprise Google Drive and Google Sheets were chosen for their ease of use, but their limitations exposed inefficiencies, including manual processes that increased workload. This highlighted the need for more streamlined, automated solutions in future efforts.

“.... Another important aspect of data management was ensuring the security and integrity of data as it traveled through various networks. The risk of losing control over data, or even copyright issues when it passes through third-party services, was a significant concern. Many platforms scan incoming traffic and potentially retain copies for system improvements, which can complicate copyright and ownership rights. Navigating this gray area, we made concerted efforts to keep our data within our secure university network as much as possible, storing it on university devices and limiting its movement through external services

unless absolutely necessary. The one exception was providing access to our industry partner, which we used as our primary platform due to the immediate needs of the project and the preferences of our stakeholders. This decision remains in place as we plan further studies and benchmark speech recognition software and models for future improvements.” – Author4

Additionally, ensuring the security and integrity of the data as it moved between networks was a major concern. The risk of losing control over the data or encountering copyright issues when using third-party platforms requires careful navigation. Despite these risks, Enterprise Google Drive remained the primary platform due to project demands, but efforts were made to limit unnecessary movement of data to external services.

The complexities of data management in this project extend beyond technical challenges, intersecting with profound ethical and cultural considerations. While robust data practices were crucial for the project’s success, they also laid the groundwork for more accurate AI technologies capable of understanding and responding to AAVE. However, this technological advancement brings with it a host of ethical dilemmas. The very act of collecting, managing, and utilizing AAVE data raises questions about cultural preservation, potential misappropriation, and the changing dynamics of a historically protected form of communication. These concerns highlight the delicate balance researchers must strike between technological progress and cultural sensitivity, a balance that becomes even more critical when considering the unique perspectives and responsibilities of Black researchers in this field.

AAVE has historically functioned as a codified form of communication, enabling African Americans to navigate spaces of oppression while maintaining a sense of cultural identity and community. Making AAVE more accessible through speech recognition technology could dilute its protective nature, exposing it to widespread usage by those outside the community who may not respect its cultural significance. Further, the risk of cultural misappropriation where non-Black individuals or industries exploit AAVE terms and phrases for profit, stripping them of their context and meaning.

“As a researcher, I have shared my participation in this project with many of my friends and family. Many have shown enthusiasm ... often excited to learn that I am traveling to engage people from around the country about their use of AAVE. But many have also challenged the efficacy of this work toward dismantling the protections of AAVE dialects and discourse as a means of codified engagement. “What if we don’t want Big Brother to better understand what we are saying? Sometimes it’s good that others don’t get it.” This critique of our motives is valid and something that I as a researcher often grapple with internally. The question shifts from ‘How we should do [X]?’ to ‘Should we do [X]?’. In this case [X] being the increased responsiveness of automatic speech recognition systems to AAVE.” – Author3

Additionally, Black HBCU researchers bring a critical and nuanced lens to this work. Informed by lived experiences and deep understanding of the cultural, historical, and social contexts surrounding the African American community and the Black data ecosystem. As both participants and facilitators in the research processes, Black researchers are often tasked with advocating for culturally relevant methodologies, challenging institutional norms and pushing back against systemic biases in data and technology. This multifaceted role—being both a representative of the community and a professional in predominantly white and corporate environments—places Black researchers in a unique but complex position. We must continually negotiate their positionality while ensuring the research remains rooted in empathy and equity, amplifying community voices while maintaining scholarly rigor, and navigating the expectations of industry partners or funding bodies that may not fully grasp the community’s needs and vulnerabilities.

4 Recommendations

Table 1 provides a set of detailed recommendations for conducting collaborative large-scale data collection efforts. These recommendations are based on our experiences and insights gained during our project and are designed to address key challenges such as trust-building, effective resource management, and navigating equitable power dynamics. The table outlines strategies for fostering transparency and trust with participants, ensuring community engagement remains central to the process, leveraging resources efficiently, and navigating the complexities of academic and industry partnerships. By following these guidelines, future collaborations can better align with community interests while advancing technological goals responsibly.

Table 1: Recommendations for Large-Scale Data Collection Centering the Black Community

Category	Recommendation
Trust & Data Ethics	Develop clear, FAIR AI usage guidelines; involve participants in reviewing these guidelines and adjusting based on their feedback to ensure transparency.
	Ensure institutional compensation processes are clearly defined and tested before the study begins to avoid any trust-related issues.
	Use scalable, encrypted data management platforms with role-based access controls (RBAC) and multi-factor authentication (MFA) to ensure data security.

Continued on next page

Table 1: Recommendations for Large-Scale Data Collection Centering the Black Community (Continued)

Community Engagement	Regularly audit data integrity and security; keep participants informed about how their data is used, ensuring ongoing trust.
	Hold events centered on celebrating the Black community’s contributions, ensuring participants feel valued without expectations.
	Create spaces for open discussions on ethical data use, allowing the community to share concerns and understand potential risks they may face in the future.
	Regularly update the community on project progress and future goals, fostering a long-term, mutually beneficial relationship.
Resource Leverage & Management	If partnerships with organizations are unavailable, engage through alternative venues like local churches, libraries, and community centers to reach participants.
	Maintain monthly check-ins with key contacts, keeping communication lines open to address potential bottlenecks and process changes.
	Take advantage of the flexibility and responsiveness of smaller startups to tailor tools for specific research needs, even if they lack full documentation.
Power Dynamics	Engage community organizations and startups with flexibility.
	Acknowledge the historical exploitation of Black communities in research, ensuring that power dynamics are carefully navigated.
	Negotiate mutually beneficial outcomes with external partners, ensuring both the institution and community benefits equally.

5 Conclusion

Our case study presents the challenges and opportunities that emerge when an HBCU engages in large-scale data collection within the Black community. The positionality of researchers within our core team being both community members and academic researchers created unique advantages and responsibilities through

the data collection process. Our collaboration with an industry partner demonstrated the potential for meaningful partnerships that respect community interests while advancing technological equity. We encountered challenges in data management, participant compensation, and power dynamics that yielded valuable lessons, while also highlighting the critical role HBCUs play in ensuring ethical data practices and community representation in AI development. We present recommendations for four areas including: trust and data ethics, community engagement, resource leverage and management, and power dynamics (see Table 1). While our reflections offer critical insights into the narrative development and framing process within the Black data ecosystem, we acknowledge the limitations of this case study in disentangling narratives shaped by institutional and industry mandates from those influenced by our personal biases and positionalities. This intersection underscores the complexities of navigating power dynamics, as the narratives co-constructed during this process may unintentionally reflect a blend of external expectations and subjective interpretations rather than wholly independent framing. As AI continues to evolve, the insights gained from this case study can be used to inform more equitable and responsible approaches to data collection, particularly with communities of color. By centering Black voices and experiences in the development of AI technologies, we move closer to a future where technological advancement and cultural preservation can coexist.

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